



Clockwise from left, designer Iba Mallai at Rynsan, an assortment at Kai Nung, designer Daniel Syiem at the same, putharo and prawns at Rynsan, and shredded pork with local herb chutney at the same

WHAT THE LOCALS EAT

Shillong's foodies recommend their favourite restaurants, from venerable old spots to innovative new ones

KARISHMA UPADHYAY / *Photographs by* **HARDIK CHHABRA**

There are some things you can be fairly certain of when you're visiting Shillong—a city that, as a travel destination, isn't exactly new. First and most reliably, there will be pork; lots of it. There will be maddening traffic. You'll be guzzling 'red' tea to ward off the cold, all while enjoying the prettiest of views. There will be mind-bending tastings, fiery chutneys washed down with local fruit wines and some of the best Indo-Chinese in the country.

When it comes to discovering the bones of a city though, there are few experiences as revealing (or as satisfying) as exploring its food scene. We asked Shillong's foodies for eating joints that left the strongest impression on their taste buds. From fine dining to bold flavours of indigenous culinary traditions, this list has the best of what Shillong has to offer.

Kai Nung

A little over a year old, Kai Nung (meaning 'heart of the house' in Rongmei) specialises in food from across the Northeast. Here, Manipuri Eromba (fermented fish and seasonal vegetable chutney) finds space on the menu alongside Garo Do'o Kappa (green chicken curry) and a simple Mizo-style stir-fry of Khanghu (climbing wattle). And, it reflects chef and owner Fufu Pomei's passion for little-known ingredients and dishes from the region. She even grows a lot of the greens that aren't easily available in Shillong. A speciality at Kai Nung is their snail dishes. "Depending on whether snails are from the river or paddy fields, the preparation of the dish changes. One is cooked with axone (fermented soybean) and the other Manipuri-style with jaiur and michinga (local varieties of Sichuan) leaves," says designer Daniel Syiem. The space is simple and homey, and the food tastes like something your grandmother might make—if she was a Northeasterner.

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